

# A TRANSFORMED COMMUNITY

**TEXT:** Matthew 5:14-16 *“You are the light of the world. A city that is set on a hill cannot be hidden.”*

**INTRO:** (Welcome Mark & Latisha Andrews, Martha Smith, Staff and Faculty of BETA Academy)

Christ followers are told in Scripture:

- We are the light of the world...
- We are salt...
- We are light...

In short, we are the active ingredients to transform culture. We are not supposed to be adapting to culture, placating culture, we are to be creating, setting, transforming culture.

Therefore, we have entities like Community Transformation Church and BETA Academy.

Please let me take you on a trip down memory lane:

- Susan and I came to Houston in 2001...
- We inherited a church that had been in this community since 1983... (18 years)
- Though the church was a great church, it had little to no effect on this community...
- As soon as we arrived, I started getting pressure to sell the church and relocate...
- I chose not to entertain the idea of a relocation for five years...
- In 2006 I fasted 21 days about the matter...
- The Lord said, *“Do not move this church, reach this community.”*
- When I told the leaders of the church what I believed the Lord had said to me, one leader said, *“If you do what you have suggested, you are going to reach blacks, Asians, and*

*mexicans - and we are not going to go to church with them!”*

- (Never try to take on a person who just fasted 21 days) I responded, *“Then you should probably go sooner rather than later!”*
- This leader told me that I would be losing lots of people in a short amount of time because of my decision.
- We lost 350 people in 45 days.
- Someone said to me recently, *“Can you imagine what this church would be if we had kept the people who left?”* I said, *“Most of the people who are here could not be here if some of the people who left would have stayed.”*

In the last 24 years, this church has gone from being known as *“The church with a steeple”* to a church that *“Transforms its community.”*

Remember, an institution is not who it says it is, it is who THEY (The Community) say it is!

Every local church should be God's agent of change, healing, and renewal. When the church shines its light, communities are lifted. When it hides that light, darkness prevails.

Very quickly, please allow me to talk to you about three things (There are really 7 things) a church must do if it wishes to transform the community where it is located:

## **MORAL TRANSFORMATION**

When we first arrived in Houston in 2001, Almeda Genoa Road was littered with:

- Bath houses...
- Beer joints...
- Psychics and palm readers...
- Pay-by-the-hour motels...

(The Business Administrator at the time put a potential staff member and his family at one of the pay-by-the-hour motels) We started doing prayer walks and drive by prayer for these businesses to shut down, and be replaced by reputable businesses:

- The bath houses and beer joints, shut down... (Story of talking to the owner of one of the beer joints)
- The pay by the hour motels went out of business. (Wal Mart bought some of them and bull dozed them to make room for a super center)
- The Psychics went out of business... (I thought someone should have seen that coming)
- Thousands of homes and several schools have been built in the neighborhood...

Every God-fearing institution, that hopes to bring about Community Transformation must take Moral Authority in its community.

Moral Authority is simply changing the Atmosphere through whatever means necessary.

Matthew 5:16 ***“Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works...”***  
(This little light of mine...)

A community is shaped by what the church is willing to tolerate. When the church raises the standard of righteousness, it influences the moral compass of its surroundings. People begin to see a better way to live when they see believers live with integrity, purity, and compassion.

### **Illustration:**

Cabo San Lucas – Crime went down 30% - All we did was establish a presence – Pray for change – Pick up trash – Do outreaches – and

minister to the felt needs of the residents of the complex.

We didn't protest — we modeled our Moral Authority and in turn we shifted the culture of the Community.

## **SPIRITUAL TRANSFORMATION**

Spiritual Transformation is simply bringing hope where there is no hope. *“Hope is the anchor of the soul.”* Spiritual Transformation anchors the mind, will, and emotions of the Community that previously had no hope.

The church is the spiritual covering for the region in which it is located. When we pray, we push back darkness. When we preach Christ, we open the way for healing, salvation, and freedom. Communities change when strongholds are broken, and hearts are turned to God. 2 Chronicles 7:14 *“If my people, who are*

*called by my name, will humble themselves and pray...”*

When we change the Spiritual Climate in a community, we have taken an essential step toward Community Transformation.

## **EDUCATIONAL TRANSFORMATION**

As goes academia, so goes the nation. Please know, one of these essential elements to Community Transformation cannot do the job alone. It takes all three elements, working hand in hand to Transform a Community.

When I knew the Lord was leading CT Church to stay in this Community for the purpose of Community Transformation, I knew it would take Moral Transformation, Spiritual Transformation and Educational Transformation. I didn't know how we would be able to tackle all three. But we prayed, trusted the Lord, and took the next logical step by faith.

We often become paralyzed by waiting to hear a booming voice from the sky, when we just need to take the next logical step by faith.

In 2010 Latisha Andrews approached me about bringing a small Christian School of 33 students to CT. I was an immediate yes, because I knew we had to have an Educational footprint in this Community if we hoped to Transform the area.

Laticia made a couple unsuccessful attempts to acquire a charter – With the help of CT Church. In 2013 Responsive Education Charter Schools approached me about opening a Charter School at our newly acquired Pasadena Campus (This school is still going). Latisha was hired as the principal and knocked it out of the park for two years.

In 2015 BETA Academy was granted a charter and started their school on this very property.

(Tell the story of the challenges of getting the facilities ready – thank Fred Floyd)

BETA started with 480 students – Ten years later two schools have been built by BETA in this community and the enrollment has topped 1,700 students. **(PLACE PICS OF THE TWO NEW SCHOOLS ON THE SCREEN)**

If we hope to Transform the Community and the nation, the people of God **MUST** get involved in the educational space. Hosea 4:6 ***“My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge...”***

Once Transformation begins to happen, it is sustained through education. When the church invests in education it builds a foundation for lasting change. If we are going to Transform a Community, we must help people read, learn, grow, and think biblically.

When we teach a child, biblically educate an adult, or train a worker, we are not only shaping

their future, but we are also fundamentally changing the trajectory of a Community!

In the last twelve years Responsive Education Pasadena, BETA Academy, Transformation Christian Academy, and Community Transformation Church have partnered to educate close to 20,000 scholars!!!

## **CONCLUSION:**

The church was never meant to hunker in a bunker, it is a lighthouse that is meant to guide people to a better place, morally, spiritually and educationally. Matthew 5:14-16 ***“You are the light of the world. A city that is set on a hill cannot be hidden.”***

- Recognize Latisha and Martha
- Recognize Fred Floyd
- Recognize Christina Harris and all Transformation Christian Academy faculty and staff

- Recognize Susan Nordin and Kingdom Leaders Academy
- Recognize Susan Paul and Timothy Connection
- Recognize Formed Institute and Blake and Susan Paul
- Recognize Next Steps and Foundations, and Joey and Maudi Cabrera
- Recognize Connect Track and Jeremy and Larissa Floyd

Have any other Educators in the building to come forward.